2027 Agent Quick Reference Guide

Special Supplemental Benefits for the Chronically Ill (SSBCI)



Special Supplemental Benefits for the Chronically Ill

Special Supplemental Benefits for the Chronically Ill (SSBCI) is a program that allows Medicare Advantage plans to offer additional benefits to members with one or more qualifying chronic conditions, who are at high risk for hospitalization or adverse health outcomes and who require intensive care coordination.

SSBCI allows Medicare Advantage plans to offer non-medical and non-primarily health-related benefits, such as healthy food and approved utilities, tailored to individuals with serious chronic illnesses. SSBCI offerings vary by plan and are not available on all plans.

Why does SSBCI matter to UnitedHealthcare members?



SSBCI allows Medicare Advantage plans to offer non-primarily health-related benefits tailored to the unique needs of chronically ill individuals, such as the healthy food and utilities benefit.

Benefits vary by plan and area.

2027 changes

For plan year 2027, CMS clarified how to interpret SSBCI eligibility requirements.

We cannot apply an overarching policy that members who have a chronic condition are inherently at high risk of hospitalization and need care coordination. We must publish objective criteria and demonstrate the member has met each element independently. Previously, we allowed 60 days for the member to access SSBCI benefits while we verified whether they qualified for SSBCI benefits. For any new enrollments with an effective date of 10/1 or after, members will not have the temporary access to healthy food and utilities during verification.

We will look at all our resources such as the member's health assessment to minimize member disruption. We have developed criteria with members in mind and continue to check for changes in a member's conditions and status. However, we know a small portion of members will not qualify for SSBCI benefits.

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What does this mean for C-SNP and D-SNP members?



SSBCI benefits

Qualifying C-SNP and D-SNP members will be able to use their OTC credit on covered healthy food and utilities (D-SNP members only) like electricity or home heat such as natural gas and transportation in select markets once their SSBCI is verified.



To access SSBCI benefits, members must meet several requirements:

- Diagnosis of a qualifying chronic condition
- Being identified as high risk for hospitalization or adverse health outcomes
  - Under UnitedHealthcare objective criteria, members who qualify for a Low Income Subsidy (LIS) status are determined to be at high risk of hospitalization or other adverse health outcomes.
- Being identified as requiring intensive care coordination
  - Under UnitedHealthcare's objective criteria, a qualifying Special Needs Plan (SNP) member is determined to require intensive care coordination.

Therefore, not all UnitedHealthcare C-SNP and D-SNP members will qualify for healthy food or utilities (D-SNP members only).



SSBCI does not apply to Part D benefits.

SSBCI only applies to Part C and does not include benefits related to prescription drugs or Part D. Drug costs will vary by individual and plan.

Benefits, features and/or devices may vary by plan/area. Limitations, exclusions and/or network restrictions may apply. OTC, food and utilities benefits have expiration timeframes. Review the Evidence of Coverage (EOC) for more information.

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SSBCI eligible conditions

To qualify for SSBCI benefits, members must have one or more qualifying conditions, be at high risk of hospitalization or adverse health outcomes and need care coordination. Keep in mind, **SSBCI verification is different from the C-SNP enrollment verification**.

1 **Qualifying Chronic Condition**

+

2 **High Risk of Hospitalization or Adverse Health Outcome**

Members receiving LIS qualify as high risk for hospitalization

+

3 **Needing Intensive Care Coordination**

Members enrolling in a SNP qualify as needing intensive care coordination

Below is the list of UnitedHealthcare 2027 SSBCI D-SNP qualifying conditions (may vary by carrier):

- ❑ Diabetes mellitus (type 1 or type 2)
- ❑ Cardiovascular disorders
- ❑ Chronic heart failure
- ❑ Chronic hypertension (chronic high blood pressure)
- ❑ Chronic hyperlipidemia (chronic high cholesterol)
- ❑ Autoimmune disorders
- ❑ Cancer
- ❑ Chronic alcohol use disorder and other substance use disorders (SUDs)
- ❑ Chronic gastrointestinal disease
- ❑ Chronic kidney disease (CKD)
- ❑ Chronic lung disorders
- ❑ Chronic and disabling mental health conditions
- ❑ Dementia
- ❑ HIV/AIDS
- ❑ Immunodeficiency and immunosuppressive disorders
- ❑ Myasthenia Gravis/Myoneural Disorders and Guillain-Barre Syndrome/Inflammatory and Toxic Neuropathy
- ❑ Neurologic disorders
- ❑ Overweight, obesity and metabolic syndrome
- ❑ Post-organ transplantation care
- ❑ Severe hematologic disorders
- ❑ Stroke
- ❑ Conditions associated with cognitive impairment
- ❑ Conditions with functional challenges and require similar services including spinal cord injuries, paralysis, limb loss, stroke and arthritis

Information is also available on CMS.gov.

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SSBCI vs. C-SNP verification

D-SNP SSBCI verification

SSBCI verification only

SSBCI VERIFICATION

Verifies eligibility for healthy food, utility and other supplemental benefits

23 Qualifying Chronic Conditions **+** High Risk For Hospitalization[1] **+** Needing Intensive Care Coordination[2]

Determines eligibility for SSBCI benefits. If not eligible or not verified for SSBCI, the **member remains enrolled** in the D-SNP but will not have access to SSBCI benefits.

C-SNP + SSBCI verification

C-SNP verification includes plan verification and SSBCI verification

PLAN VERIFICATION

Verifies the qualifying chronic condition required for C-SNP enrollment

3 Qualifying Chronic Conditions (Diabetes, Chronic Heart Failure, Cardiovascular Disorders)

Determines eligibility for the C-SNP. If the qualifying chronic condition is not verified within 60 days, the member is **disenrolled** from the C-SNP.

SSBCI VERIFICATION*

Verifies eligibility for healthy food

3 Qualifying Chronic Conditions **+** High Risk For Hospitalization[1] **+** Needing Intensive Care Coordination[2]

Determines eligibility for SSBCI benefits. If not eligible or not verified for SSBCI, **the member remains enrolled** in the C-SNP (if C-SNP verified) but will not have access to SSBCI benefits.

[1]Under UnitedHealthcare objective criteria, members with a qualifying chronic condition and verified LIS status are determined to be at high risk of hospitalization or other adverse health outcomes.
[2]Under UnitedHealthcare objective criteria, a qualifying SNP member is determined to require intensive care coordination after having met the requirements for a qualifying condition and high risk of hospitalization.
**A member may be approved for SSBCI benefits while C-SNP verification remains pending if the qualifying condition is independently verified and all other SSBCI criteria are met. SSBCI eligibility may change over time as the plan receives new information. We may confirm, continue, or update a member's eligibility based on the most current information available.*

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Current UnitedHealthcare members

UnitedHealthcare aims to make the transition to SSBCI benefits seamless for most current members. Current members not verified will receive a letter asking them to complete an eligible condition verification form.

New member and plan change journey

Enrollment

Member must self-indicate their condition on enrollment.

Plan Effective

Members who self-indicate a qualifying condition during enrollment will not have access to SSBCI benefits during the SSBCI verification process.*

Provider Notified

Member receives status reminders for verification. Agent tracks status in Jarvis Book of Business.

*Not all D-SNPs offer healthy food and utilities

Verification determinations

If member is verified

If we are able to verify that the member has met the SSBCI criteria, they will have access to the healthy food and utilities (D-SNP only) benefits through the end of the year.

If member is NOT verified

If we are unable to verify that the member meets all three CMS qualifying criteria within the first 60 days on the plan, members will not have access to the healthy food and utilities benefits. They will still have access to OTC, wellness support** and fitness benefits as rewards and discounts (if available on the member's plan).

**Only D-SNP members qualify for wellness support benefit.

IMPORTANT! If a member does not self-indicate during enrollment, they can indicate their condition online in the member site, UnitedHealthcare app or by calling UnitedHealthcare.

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Frequently asked questions (FAQ)

Eligibility:

How is the qualifying condition verified?
The qualifying condition needs to be verified using existing health plan data or by the member's treating provider.

What if the consumer or member is unsure whether they have a qualifying condition?
The consumer or member may self-indicate they have a qualifying condition and allow UnitedHealthcare to attempt to verify the condition and other qualifying criteria.

Will a member be notified when their SSBCI eligibility is verified?
A confirmation letter will be sent via their preferred delivery method after verifying a member's SSBCI eligibility. Their UCard will be updated within 24-48 hours to allow them to use their credit on covered healthy food and approved utilities (D-SNP only).

How will we notify members who do not qualify?
If UnitedHealthcare cannot verify that a member meets the SSBCI criteria, they will receive a letter letting them know they do not meet the SSBCI criteria as of the date indicated in their letter and their benefit will be OTC and wellness support,* such as select fitness items or assistance through The Helper Bees for in-home services, weight management counseling, caregiver relief and more. If a member who doesn't initially qualify is diagnosed with a qualifying condition later, the healthy food and utilities* benefit will be granted once we confirm the diagnosis and SSBCI eligibility. To view examples of member SSBCI verification communications, go to SSBCI Member Communications.

*Only D-SNP members qualify for utilities and wellness support benefit.

Will members be disenrolled from their plan if we are unable to obtain documentation verifying the SSBCI qualifying criteria?
No, members will not be disenrolled from their plan if we cannot verify **SSBCI eligibility**. Members who do not qualify for healthy food and approved utilities (D-SNP members only) will still be able to access their OTC benefit. D-SNP members will have access to wellness offerings such as weight management coaching, fitness wearables, fitness equipment, home care and respite care.

What happens when a C-SNP member is verified as eligible for enrollment in a C-SNP but cannot be verified for SSBCI eligibility?
If C-SNP members do not meet the SSBCI criteria, their benefit will be OTC only.

Are members able to see if they are eligible for SSBCI?
A member can track their qualification status by logging on to their member site, in the UnitedHealthcare app or by calling customer service.

Does the provider verify all three CMS qualifying criteria for access to healthy food and approved utilities (D-SNP only) for SSBCI benefits?
No, UnitedHealthcare uses clinical data to determine whether a member meets all three criteria. We will continue to outreach to a provider for condition verification if we are unable to substantiate it internally.

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Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ), cont.

What happens if a provider states that the member does not have a qualifying condition prior to the end of the verification process?
We will continue to outreach to a provider for condition verification if we are unable to substantiate it internally, if provided, and continue to search internal data weekly. The member will get a letter that they are not eligible to have access to healthy food and utilities (unless their condition is later confirmed). We stop all provider outreach after 60 days.

What happens if a member is diagnosed with a condition more than 60 days after their plan effective date?
If UnitedHealthcare cannot verify that a member has a qualifying condition, they will receive a letter letting them know they will not have access to spend their credit on healthy food and utilities (D-SNP members only) as of the date indicated in their letter. If a member who doesn't initially qualify is diagnosed with a qualifying condition later, the healthy food and utilities benefit will be granted once we confirm the diagnosis and SSBCI eligibility. The members will be able to use their credit for healthy food and utilities immediately upon confirmation. Plan members who don't qualify can continue to use their credit to buy covered OTC products and, if D-SNP, certain home support services or to buy covered fitness equipment and activity trackers, based on plan design.

What are some of the *reasons* UnitedHealthcare cannot reach or locate a provider to verify a member's qualifying condition?
Some reasons include:
- Incorrect provider information was entered when the application was submitted or when the member self-indicated
- UnitedHealthcare cannot find the provider's contact information

What *happens* if UnitedHealthcare cannot reach or locate a provider to verify a member's qualifying condition?
A letter is mailed to the member informing them they cannot access their additional benefits (beyond OTC and wellness support (if applicable)) until we reach their provider. The letter also informs the member to call UnitedHealthcare Member Services and update their provider information. The member can go on their member site or UnitedHealthcare app to select a network provider and self-indicate for a qualifying condition.

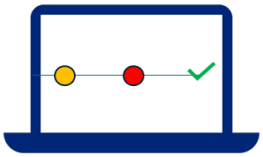
Plan changes:

If we have verified the member on one plan and then they change to another plan with SSBCI benefits mid-year, will they have to re-verify?
A verified member who switches plans from one UnitedHealthcare plan with SSBCI benefits to another UnitedHealthcare plan will be considered SSBCI verified and have access to OTC and healthy food and utilities depending on plan offering.

If a member changes to a new plan with SSBCI benefits before verifying for healthy food and utilities, will they need to self-indicate again?
Yes.

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SSBCI resources

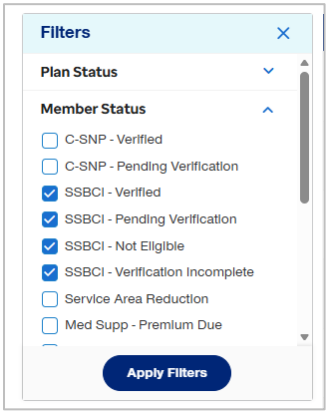


Jarvis Book of Business

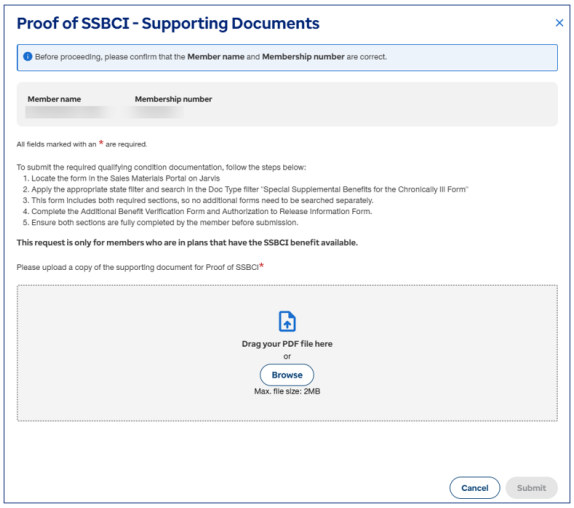
You can quickly track member verification status and upload SSBCI verification documentation for members in your Book of Business on Jarvis. Review the Book of Business User Guide in Learning Lab for more information.

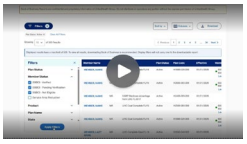
Use the "Member Status" filter to view your member's SSBCI verification status.

1. Go to Book of Business and select "Filters"
2. Select the dropdown for "Member Status" and select SSBCI filters
3. Click "Apply Filters"



In the "Service Request" tab, follow the instructions to upload your member's completed Additional Benefits Verification Form and Authorization to Release Information Form.





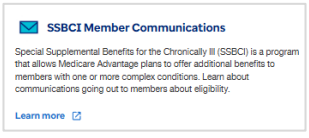
Book of Business video in Learning Lab

Learn about the enhancements with the Book of Business in our Jarvis course on Learning Lab. This video will walk you through how to utilize the features built within the Book of Business.



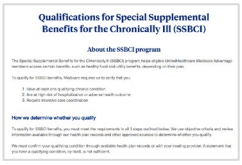
SSBCI national webinar

Register for our SSBCI national webinar on Jarvis. In this live webinar you will be able to interact with our trainers on the topic of SSBCI and explore ways to retain your members if they do not verify for SSBCI benefits.



Member SSBCI communications

Click the link below to learn about communications going out to members about eligibility. 2027 communications coming soon.
SSBCI Member Communications



Public-Facing SSBCI Website

Direct members to the public-facing website for a clear, member-friendly overview of SSBCI qualifications. Public-facing SSBCI website

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